

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a lifestyle magazine:

Night Owls

'Night owls' are people who are naturally more awake and active at night and tend to go to bed late. Research has found that night owls face higher rates of poor health, including having a 10 percent higher risk of dying younger than 'early birds' or people who get up early and feel more energetic first thing in the day. Night owls often suffer from long-term lack of sleep and this can increase the chance of diabetes, heart disease and obesity. Not having enough sleep even for just one night can make us moody; when it happens every single night for an extended period, depression can develop.



Associate professor Kristen Knutson at Northwestern University said: "This is a public health issue that cannot be ignored. We need to recognise that people have different body clocks which regulate the time we feel sleepy and wakeful throughout the day. Some people naturally wake up early while others feel more awake at night. All of this comes down to a combination of genes and the person's environment."

Employers can benefit from adjusting start times to suit individual employees' needs. Another study found that when companies let night owls start work later in the day or allowed them to work from home, there was an estimated US\$277m gain in productivity. It argues that people who are more awake at night should be allowed to start and finish work later. Not everyone is suited to get up for an 8am start.

Your group is doing a project on sleeping patterns and you are meeting to discuss this. You may want to talk about:

- the advantages of being a night owl
- the advantages of getting up early
- whether companies should have flexible working hours for people with different sleeping patterns
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you wake up early on weekends?
2. Do you often have problems waking up in the morning?
3. What do you do if you cannot fall asleep?
4. What do you do to keep yourself awake when you are sleepy?
5. Have you ever overslept for something important?
6. What time of the day are you most productive?
7. Would you consider a job that requires working at night?
8. Do you envy people who only need a few hours of sleep?